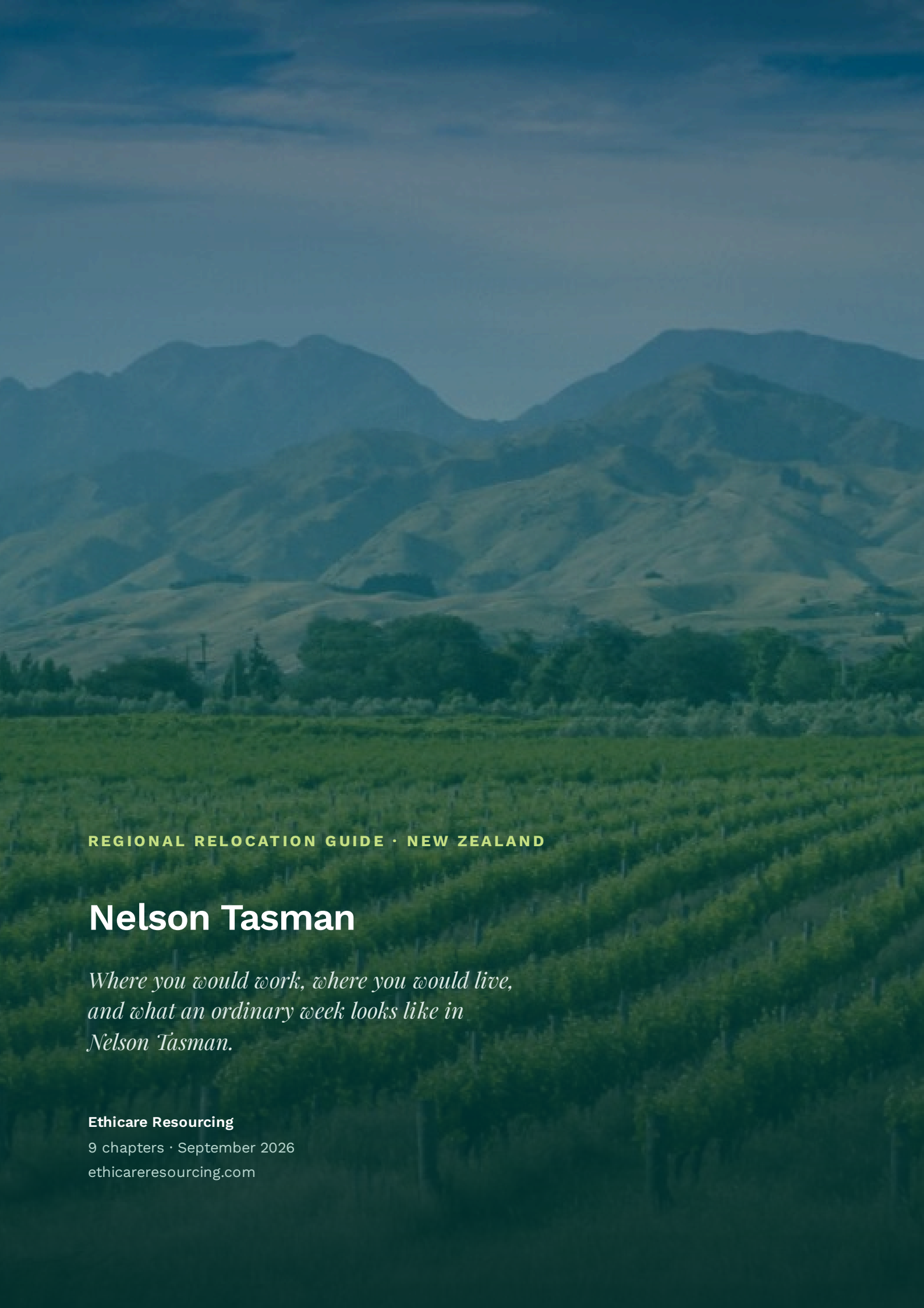




REGIONAL RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Nelson Tasman

*Where you would work, where you would live,
and what an ordinary week looks like in
Nelson Tasman.*

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Nelson Tasman

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Nau mai, haere mai ki Whakatū. Nelson Tasman sits at the top of the South Island, wrapped around a sheltered bay, with three national parks within reach and more sunshine than anywhere else in New Zealand. It is, by fairly common agreement, one of the loveliest places in the country to live.

Sun, sea and three national parks

Nelson is a city of around fifty-five thousand at the head of Tasman Bay, with the Tasman District spreading west through Richmond, Māpua and Motueka to Golden Bay beyond the hill. Together they hold about a hundred and ten thousand people, and the geography is extraordinarily generous: a warm sheltered coastline on one side, mountains and beech forest on the other, and orchards and vineyards on the plains between.

Three national parks are within a comfortable drive — **Abel Tasman** with its golden beaches, **Kahurangi** with the Heaphy Track, and **Nelson Lakes** with its alpine water. No other city in New Zealand has that. Nelson also has a real arts and craft community, a proper food and craft-beer culture, and the country's oldest surviving cathedral city centre.

The clinical picture: a base hospital in Nelson serving the whole region, with a smaller hospital in Blenheim over the hill in Marlborough under the same service. Complex work goes to Christchurch or Wellington. The honest cost is housing — Nelson is expensive for its size, for exactly the reasons you would expect — and a certain isolation, since this is the top of the South Island and everything is a ferry or a flight away.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Nelson sells itself, which is why we spend most of our time here talking about the housing market rather than the beaches. Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The region, in nine numbers

~110,000

People across Nelson city and the Tasman District, from Golden Bay to St Arnaud.

~55,000

In Nelson itself, with Richmond about fifteen thousand and Motueka around eight.

~2,400 hrs

Of sunshine a year. Nelson holds the title of sunniest city in New Zealand most years, and it is the region's defining fact.

1 base hospital

In Nelson, with a second hospital in Blenheim, both run by Health New Zealand I Te Whatu Ora across the Nelson Marlborough district.

3 national parks

Abel Tasman, Kahurangi and Nelson Lakes. No other New Zealand city can claim that.

~10 min

A typical commute. Nelson is compact and flat along the coast, and Richmond is twenty minutes out.

~5–6 hrs

To Christchurch by road, where much of the region's tertiary work goes. Wellington is a short flight or a ferry from Picton.

Expensive

Housing, for a city this size. Lifestyle demand from the rest of the country has pushed prices well above what local incomes would suggest.

8 iwi

Of Te Tau Ihu, the top of the South Island — a more complex iwi landscape than most regions, and an active one in health.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The sunshine is the whole point

Around 2,400 hours a year, sheltered from the prevailing westerly by the ranges. It shapes how you live, what grows, and why so many people are here.

Housing is the sting

Nelson costs more than a city of fifty-five thousand should, because half the country would like to retire here. This is the one number that surprises clinicians. [Cost of living](#) is direct about it.

Richmond is the practical answer

Twenty minutes from Nelson, closer to the hospital than much of the city, and materially cheaper. A lot of clinical families end up there and are glad they did.

It is a genuine arts town

Not a marketing line. A real community of potters, jewellers, glass artists, painters and makers, and a craft culture that goes back decades.

You are a long way from anywhere

The top of the South Island is beautiful and it is remote. Christchurch is five or six hours, the ferry to Wellington leaves from Picton two hours away, and long-haul means a connection.

Golden Bay is another world

Over the Tākaka Hill, an hour and a half from Nelson — a famously alternative, close-knit community with its own rhythm entirely.

A note on names

Whakatū is Nelson in te reo Māori. This is Te Tau Ihu o te Waka a Māui — the prow of Māui's canoe — and the rohe of eight iwi, a more layered landscape than most regions. Whakarewā is the Māitai valley; Mohua is Golden Bay.

You're not expected to arrive fluent. You are expected to try. [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation and the words you'll hear on the ward.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Nelson Tasman specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally — visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools — lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Nelson Tasman](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Cost of living](#), because the housing market is the one thing here that needs planning for.

Why Nelson Tasman

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Nelson is the region people picture when they imagine moving to New Zealand. Warm, coastal, artistic, wrapped in national parks. All of that is true. The question is whether the arithmetic works for you, because it is tighter here than the postcard suggests.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. A nurse, radiographer, physiotherapist or sonographer on a given step earns the same in Nelson as in Auckland or Invercargill. What changes is what the money buys.

Here it buys less than you would expect. Nelson's housing costs are high relative to local incomes — not Queenstown high, but well above what a city of fifty-five thousand would normally command, because lifestyle demand from the rest of New Zealand has been pushing prices up for thirty years. You are not paid a premium for that. You are paying for the sunshine and the beaches, the same way you would in the Bay of Plenty.

What you get for it is genuinely rare: the sunniest climate in the country, three national parks, a real cultural community in a small city, and a base hospital ten minutes from home. If you go to Richmond or Motueka the numbers relax considerably, and a lot of clinicians do exactly that.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Ten to twenty minutes to work from most of Nelson or Richmond. No congestion worth the name, and easy parking.

After work

The Tahunanui beach, the Māitai river swimming holes in town, or the Grampians for the view. Long light evenings for most of the year.

Saturday

The Nelson market — one of the country's best for craft as well as produce — then a beach or a brewery.

Sunday

Abel Tasman for a walk or a water taxi, the Great Taste Trail on a bike, or Kaiteriteri. All within an hour.

A long weekend

Golden Bay over the hill, Nelson Lakes, the Marlborough Sounds, or the ferry to Wellington.

Kaikōura and the West Coast are both reachable.

Summer

Hot, dry and busy. Abel Tasman fills, the campgrounds fill, and the region's population swells.

Locals use the quieter beaches and enjoy February onwards.

The six things people ask us

Is there enough clinical work?

Can I afford to live there?

Is it too remote?

Is it a good place with children?

Is it international enough?

What is the weather really like?

When we'd steer you elsewhere

You want to buy soon

Nelson is expensive for its size. If home ownership within a couple of years is the point of the move, Southland, Palmerston North or the Waikato do it considerably faster.

Your specialty needs tertiary volume

Neurosurgery, cardiothoracics and the most complex work go to Christchurch or Wellington. If you need those volumes, you need a tertiary centre.

You need easy international travel

Every long-haul trip involves a domestic leg. Manageable, but it is a real consideration if family is far away.

You want a city

Nelson is a lovely small city with a real cultural life, but it is small. Major touring acts and big institutions mean flying.

You want a bigger community around you

If a large, established diaspora community is central to settling well, Auckland or Wellington will serve you better.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the South Island with a tertiary hospital and a real city? **Christchurch**.

Want the same sunshine and coast on the North Island, closer to everything? **Hawke's Bay**.

Want the far south with a base hospital and housing you can actually buy? **Southland**.

In our experience

Nelson suits clinicians who've decided the weekends are non-negotiable — three national parks within two hours isn't a brochure line, it's the local routine. Go in with housing eyes open and it's one of the easiest places in the country to be content.

Nelson Tasman at a glance

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

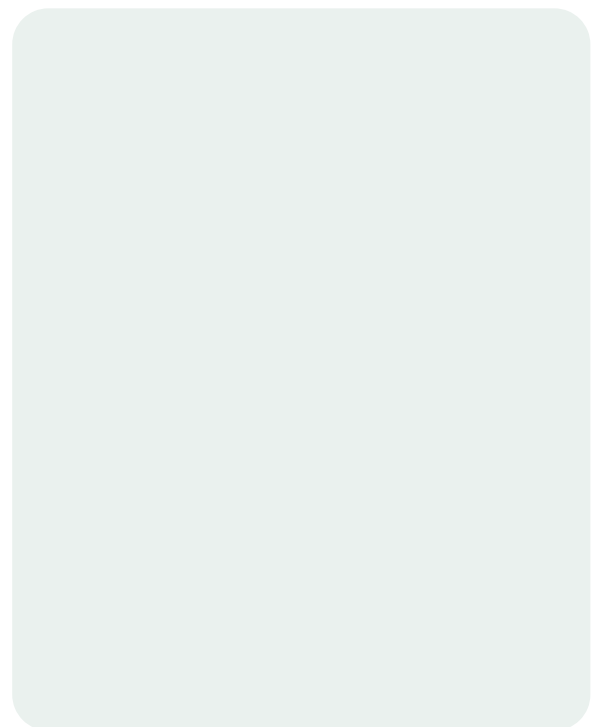
Nelson sits in a rain shadow at the head of a sheltered bay, with mountains taking the weather before it arrives. That single fact explains the sunshine, the orchards, the vineyards and why so many people want to live here.

The shape of the region

Nelson city curls around the eastern end of Tasman Bay, hemmed in by hills, with Tahunanui beach and the Boulder Bank on its seaward side. Twenty minutes south-west, **Richmond** sits on the flat Waimea plain — the region's growth area and, for many, its practical centre.

From Richmond the Tasman District runs west: Māpua on its inlet, Motueka among the orchards, and Kaiteriteri's golden sand at the edge of **Abel Tasman National Park**. Beyond that the Tākaka Hill climbs over into **Golden Bay** — Mohua — a separate world with its own famously independent community.

Inland and south, the land rises into **Kahurangi** and **Nelson Lakes** national parks: beech forest, alpine lakes, and the start of the Heaphy Track. South-east, the road to Blenheim and the Marlborough Sounds crosses the Whangamoa and Rai hills.



Where Nelson sits, with the straight-line distance to Blenheim and Motueka

The four seasons

Summer
Dec – Feb
22–26°C

Hot, dry, brilliant

Autumn

Mar – May

17–22°C

Settled and golden

Winter

Jun – Aug

12–14°C

Mild coast, frosty inland

Spring

Sep – Nov

15–20°C

Blossom, then warm

Indicative daytime highs on the coast. Inland on the Waimea plain and towards Nelson Lakes, winter frosts are routine and summer days are hotter.

What the numbers don't tell you

The sunshine is the best in New Zealand. Around 2,400 hours a year — Nelson takes the national title most years. The ranges to the west and south strip the prevailing weather of its rain before it reaches the bay, which is why this corner is so consistently bright.

Dry summers mean water restrictions. The Waimea plain is intensively horticultural and the region has had real water-supply pressure in dry years. Restrictions in summer are normal, and worth knowing if you are planning a garden.

Winters are mild on the coast and cold inland. Nelson itself rarely does anything severe. Twenty minutes inland on the plain, frost is a regular winter feature, and the alpine parks get proper snow.

The housing stock needs checking, as everywhere. Older Nelson villas are charming and frequently under-insulated. Ask about insulation, ventilation and a heat pump, and check the Healthy Homes compliance statement, which is a legal requirement and covered in the national [Renting in New Zealand](#) chapter.

The Tākaka Hill is a real piece of road. The only route to Golden Bay, and a steep winding climb over marble country. It closes occasionally in bad weather, which genuinely isolates the communities beyond it.

Where things are, in driving time

Nelson → Richmond

20 minutes across the plain. The region's most-driven route.

Nelson → Māpua

30 minutes, to the inlet and the wharf.

Nelson → Motueka

45 minutes west through the orchards.

Nelson → Kaiteriteri / Abel Tasman

About an hour to the park's southern gateway.

Nelson → Tākaka / Golden Bay

1 hr 30 over the hill. A different world when you get there.

Nelson → Blenheim / Picton / Christchurch

1 hr 45, 2 hr and 5–6 hr respectively. Picton is the ferry to Wellington.

Words you'll hear

Whakatū Nelson in te reo Māori.

Te Tau Ihu The top of the South Island – the prow of Māui's canoe.

Mohua Golden Bay, over the Tākaka Hill.

The Hill The Tākaka Hill. The only way to Golden Bay, and a conversation topic.

Tahuna Tahunanui – the city's beach and its suburb.

The Māitai The river through Nelson, and its swimming holes.

The Great Taste Trail The region's cycle trail, linking cellar doors, orchards and coast.

Centre of NZ The hill walk in Nelson marking the old survey datum. Everyone does it once.

The short version

A sheltered, sunlit bay with three national parks and the best sunshine hours in the country. Mild on the coast, frosty inland, dry in summer. The climate is why everyone wants to be here – which is also why the housing costs what it does. **Where clinicians live** is next.

Healthcare in Nelson Tasman

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Nelson Tasman offers a base hospital in a small, extremely liveable city, serving a district that stretches from Golden Bay to the Marlborough Sounds. For most professions that means real breadth without living somewhere remote.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services across the top of the South Island are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora as a single Nelson Marlborough district. There are two hospital sites: the base hospital in **Nelson**, carrying acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, imaging and outpatient services; and a smaller hospital in **Blenheim**, an hour and forty-five minutes east over the hills, serving Marlborough.

Around them: community and district services across Nelson, Richmond and the Tasman District, primary care, iwi and Māori health providers, aged residential care, and rural services reaching into Golden Bay and Murchison. Complex and highly specialised work is referred to Christchurch, five to six hours by road or a short flight, and to Wellington for some services.

ONE DISTRICT, TWO SIDES OF A MOUNTAIN RANGE

Driving times from Nelson, to scale against each other. The marked row is the one that surprises people: the district's second hospital site sits an hour and three-quarters away, over the hills.

Murchison

Well inland, and one of the rural services the district reaches



~1 hr 30

Blenheim

The district's second hospital site, over the hills – some roles involve travel between the two



~1 hr 45

Golden Bay

Behind a hill road that closes in bad weather. Access, isolation and retrieval are live considerations



~2 hours

Christchurch

Where complex and highly specialised work is referred – or a short flight instead



~5½ hours

Indicative driving times in good conditions. Ask which site your role sits at before you choose a suburb – it is the question that most often gets answered too late here.

What the work is like

Real breadth

A base hospital with no competing centre nearby means a wide caseload and more decisions carried by you. Good for clinicians who want to be capable generalists.

A genuinely rural reach

Golden Bay sits behind a hill road that closes in bad weather, and Murchison is well inland.

Access, isolation and retrieval are live considerations.

Two-site district

Nelson and Blenheim operate as one service across a mountain range. Some roles involve travel between them – ask early, because it affects where you live.

An older population

Nelson attracts retirees in significant numbers. Expect a caseload weighted towards age-related medicine, orthopaedics, oncology and chronic disease.

Seasonal and outdoor injury

Horticultural work, forestry, tramping and water sports across three national parks. A distinctive musculoskeletal and trauma load, concentrated in summer.

Recruitment is a standing challenge

Housing costs make it hard to attract and keep staff, which means genuine openness to international clinicians – and, honestly, gaps and pressure alongside it.

Working with te ao Māori

Te Tau Ihu is the rohe of eight iwi – a more layered landscape than most New Zealand regions, reflecting the history of migration and settlement at the top of the South Island. Iwi and Māori health providers are active partners in care delivery here, particularly in the rural districts and Golden Bay.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau involved in decisions. You are not expected to arrive fluent – you are expected to try. The national chapter [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

What to ask at interview

Which site, and is there cross-site working? Nelson and Blenheim are an hour and three-quarters apart over hills. Ask this before you choose a suburb.

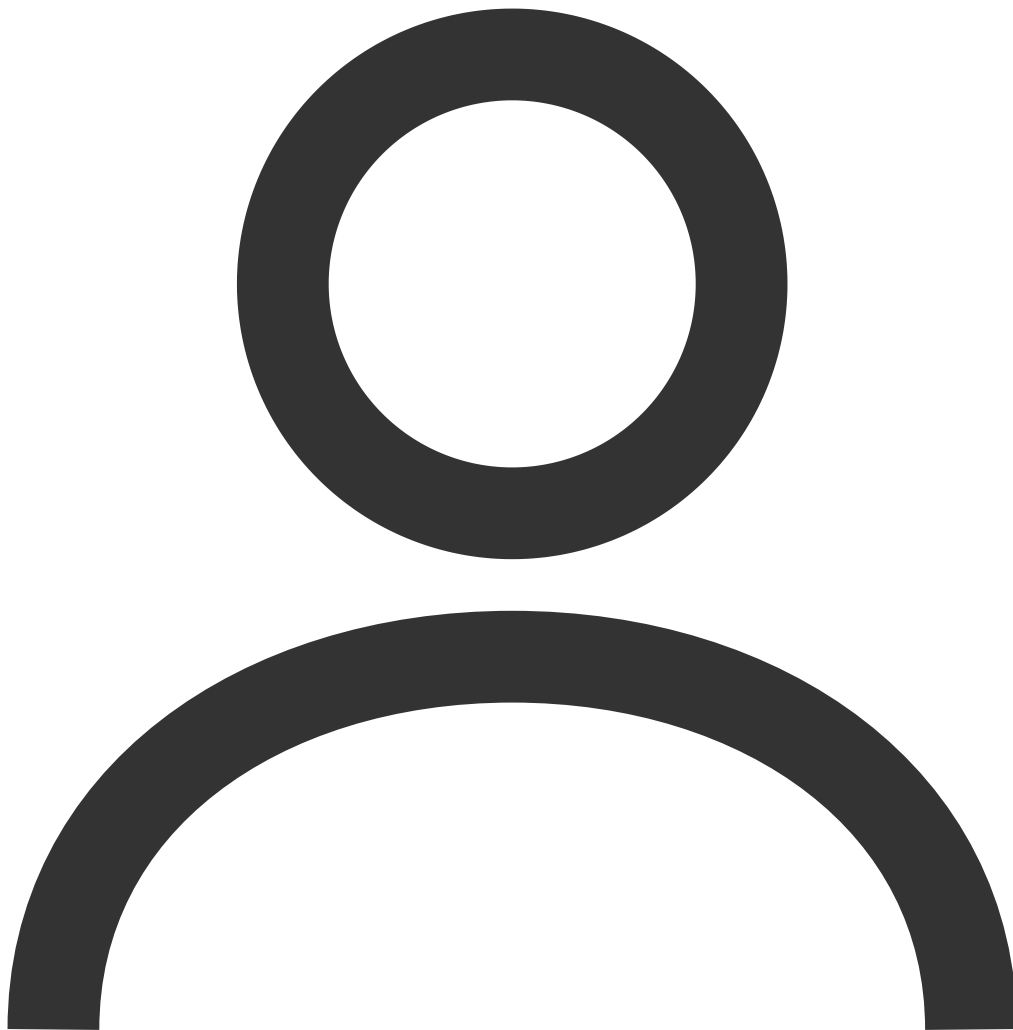
What is the on-call or rostered-hours pattern, and how is it paid under the relevant collective agreement?

What gets referred to Christchurch or Wellington in my specialty, and how much of that pathway do I stay involved in?

Is there any rural or Golden Bay outreach in the role, and how does that work when the hill road closes?

What orientation, supervision and cultural induction is there for clinicians new to New Zealand?

Is there relocation support, and any help with housing? Ask directly – it matters more here than in most regions.



Sophie

Sophie's insight

Nelson is the region that needs no selling and the one where I spend the most time on spreadsheets. The life is exactly what people imagine. My advice is always the same: look seriously at Richmond, and rent for a year before you buy anything.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured – ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system – lives in [How the health system works](#).

Ethicare

Live roles & professions



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by region.

National guide



How national collective agreements work, and what to check before you sign.

Where clinicians live

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



The decision here is mostly financial. Nelson city is lovely and expensive; Richmond and the Tasman District are lovely and considerably less so. Because commutes are short in both directions, going further out costs you very little time.

A FINANCIAL DECISION WEARING A LIFESTYLE COSTUME

Commutes stay short in every direction here, so distance barely prices in. What changes as you move down this list is what the same money buys.

The city	Villas near the cathedral, hillside views and the beach at Tahunanui – the region's dearest addresses, a short walk or drive from the hospital.
The plain	Richmond, Hope and the Waimea flats: newer, warmer houses at materially softer prices, with their own schools and shops – and for some streets a shorter hospital run than the city itself manages.
The villages	Wakefield, Māpua and the coast road beyond – community-strong settlements where the money stretches furthest and the drive stays inside half an hour.

Going further out here costs minutes, not hours – which is why the plain, not the city, is where many clinical families end up.

Nelson city

The Wood & central Nelson

Character villas and cottages walking distance from the cathedral, the shops and the Māitai. Desirable, walkable, and priced for it. Ten minutes to the hospital.

Britannia Heights & Port Hills

Elevated streets with views over the bay. Some of the region's best addresses, and the prices to match.

Tahunanui

The beach suburb – the city's main swimming beach, campground and a mixed, friendly community. Better value than the hills, and popular for it.

Stoke

Between Nelson and Richmond, and the practical middle ground. Good-value family housing, well served by schools and shops, and a short run either way.

Nelson South & Toi Toi

Close in, mixed, and among the more affordable options inside the city. Handy for the hospital.

Atawhai

North along the coast towards the Boulder Bank – quiet, sea-facing, and a straightforward ten-minute run into town.

Queen's Gardens – parkland in the middle of the city

Richmond and the Waimea plain

Richmond

Twenty minutes from Nelson on the flat, with its own shops, schools and services. Materially cheaper, newer and warmer housing, and closer to the hospital than parts of Nelson itself. The answer for a lot of clinical families.

Hope & Brightwater

Small settlements just beyond Richmond – village primary schools, more land for the money, and a twenty-five minute commute.

Wakefield

Thirty minutes out on the plain. A proper village with a strong community, and among the best value in the region.

Māpua & Ruby Bay

Thirty minutes west on the inlet – a wharf, cafés, an arts community and coastal living. Much loved, and priced accordingly.

Further out

Motueka

Forty-five minutes west among the orchards, at the gateway to Abel Tasman. A real town with its own services, a strong alternative streak, and good value.

Tākaka & Golden Bay

An hour and a half over the hill. Famously independent, close-knit and beautiful, with its own rural health service. Its own decision, not a Nelson commute.

Three things to check before you sign

Model Richmond properly. It is the single biggest financial lever in this region, and it costs you almost no time. Run the numbers before you commit to a Nelson postcode.

Insulation and ventilation. Nelson's older villas are charming and often cold. Ask for the Healthy Homes compliance statement.

The school zone, at the exact address. Popular schools here are zoned and enrolment is by address – see [Schools & education](#).

Most clinicians we move here rent for six to twelve months before buying, which is the right call in a market this tight. How renting works – the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).

Cost of living

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 7 of 9

Nelson is one of two regions in this collection where the housing market asks something real of you. It is not Queenstown — but it costs more than a city of fifty-five thousand people should, and for exactly the reason you would guess.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Nelson Tasman against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Why it costs what it does

Thirty years of people from the rest of New Zealand deciding they would like to live in the sunniest, most beautiful small city in the country. Retirees selling in Auckland and Wellington, lifestyle buyers, and a finite amount of flat land between the hills and the sea. Local wages have not kept pace, so Nelson regularly appears among the less affordable places in New Zealand relative to income.

Clinical pay is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Palmerston North or Invercargill, into a materially more expensive market. There is no regional loading to close the gap. What you are buying is 2,400 hours of sunshine and three national parks, and that is a real thing to buy — but go in knowing the price.

The good news is the lever: **Richmond**. Twenty minutes out, on the flat, newer and warmer housing, closer to the hospital than parts of Nelson itself, and meaningfully cheaper. Wakefield, Brightwater and Motueka relax the numbers further.

Renting, by area

Britannia Heights & the Port Hills

The premium end – views over the bay, and the region's highest prices. Limited stock.

The Wood & central Nelson

Character villas, walkable to everything. Charming, sought-after, and often cold – check the insulation.

Tahunanui & Atawhai

Coastal but better value than the hills. Tahunanui in particular offers beach living at a sensible price.

Stoke & Nelson South

The middle ground, and among the better value inside the city. Handy for the hospital and the schools.

Richmond, Hope & Brightwater

Materially cheaper for the same size of house, twenty to twenty-five minutes out. This is the lever.

Wakefield & Motueka

Cheaper again, with more land. Real towns with their own services, thirty to forty-five minutes out.

NELSON, OR TWENTY MINUTES DOWN THE ROAD

The same small place to live, priced by whether it has a Nelson address. This is the one decision in this chapter that moves real money.



Monthly rent for a room or small one-bedroom, expressed against Richmond as the baseline. Over a year the gap is worth more than two months' rent. Richmond is twenty to twenty-five minutes from Nelson Hospital and Wakefield thirty to forty-five – which is why the area you choose is the first thing we raise with clinicians moving here.

Indicative prices that change over time. The two rent lines are the most useful comparison in this chapter – model both before you choose a postcode.

The costs particular to here

The extra flight leg

Every long-haul trip starts with a domestic hop. Over a few trips home a year that adds up, and it is worth budgeting honestly.

Cold villas

Nelson's older housing is charming and frequently under-insulated. Paying more rent for a warm, well-insulated home is usually cheaper overall.

Water restrictions

Normal in dry summers on the Waimea plain. An adjustment rather than a cost, unless you had plans for a garden.

The outdoor habit

Bikes, kayaks, boots, a season of trips into three national parks. It is why you came, and it belongs in the budget.

Work out your own numbers

Compare cities



Nelson prices for rent, groceries, transport and dining, against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Nelson-New-Zealand>)

Plan your budget

Sorted budget planner



New Zealand's free, government-backed budgeting tool.

(<https://sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner/>)

Official data



The Household Living-Costs Price Index, updated quarterly.

(<https://www.stats.govt.nz/topics/household-living-costs-price-indexes/>)

Property



Compare Nelson, Stoke, Richmond and Motueka side by side. Do this early.

(<https://www.realestate.co.nz/residential/sale/nelson-bays>)

Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official rents



Bond-lodgement data by area – the most reliable rent figure in New Zealand.

(<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent/>)

How pay, tax, IRD numbers, KiwiSaver and sending money home actually work is national and explained once in **Money, tax & banking**.

The honest summary

You'll live well here and rent comfortably. Buying in central Nelson or the hills on one income is hard. The answer most clinicians reach is Richmond or the Waimea plain – twenty minutes out, thousands cheaper, and a warmer house. Model it properly before you fall in love with a villa.

Getting around

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



Inside the region, getting around is easy: short flat commutes and one of the country's better cycle networks. Getting out of the region is the honest cost of living at the top of the South Island.

The commute

Ten to twenty minutes to work from most of Nelson, Stoke or Richmond. There is mild congestion on the Nelson–Richmond corridor at either end of the day, and that is the whole traffic story. Parking at the hospital and in town is straightforward.

Because the region is compact along the coast and flat on the plain, going further out for cheaper housing costs remarkably little time. Richmond is twenty minutes, Wakefield thirty, Motueka forty-five. That is why the housing decision here is more about money than commute.

Cycling

The **Great Taste Trail** is one of New Zealand's Great Rides and unusually practical – a mostly flat, sealed network linking Nelson, Richmond, Māpua, Motueka and Wakefield, along coast, estuary and orchard. It connects real places, so it works for commuting as well as weekends.

Combined with the sunshine, that makes Nelson a good cycling city year-round. A number of clinicians here commute by bike or e-bike, and the trail is a large part of why.

Buses

The eBus network

Electric buses linking Nelson, Stoke, Richmond, Wakefield and Motueka. Cheap, pleasant and useful on the main corridors.

Its limits

Modest frequency, thin in the evenings, and it will not cover a clinical roster or a rural outreach role.

Do you need a car?

Yes – though possibly only one per household if you cycle and live centrally. The national parks and the beaches all assume a vehicle.

No passenger rail

None in the region. Nothing to plan around.

The roads out

The Tākaka Hill

The only route to Golden Bay – a steep, winding climb over marble country. It closes occasionally in bad weather, genuinely isolating the communities beyond.

East to Blenheim & Picton

1 hr 45 and 2 hours over the Whangamoā and Rai hills. Picton is the ferry to Wellington.

South to Christchurch

Five to six hours via the Lewis Pass or the Kaikōura coast. A long day, and a beautiful one.

West to the Coast

Down the Buller Gorge to Westport, around three hours – one of the great New Zealand drives.

Flying and the ferry

Nelson Airport

Ten minutes from the city and busy for the region's size, with frequent flights to Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch. It is what makes Nelson feel less remote than the map suggests.

The Picton ferry

Two hours to Picton, then the crossing to Wellington. The route if you're taking a car north.

Long-haul

Always via Auckland, Wellington or Christchurch. Budget a comfortable half-day at each end, and expect one more leg than from a main centre.

Weather delays

Nelson's approach is over hills into a bay. Fog and wind cause occasional delays and diversions. Build a buffer into anything that matters.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
Across Nelson	10–15 min
Nelson → airport	10 min
Nelson → Richmond	20 min
Nelson → Māpua	30 min
Nelson → Wakefield	30 min
Nelson → Motueka	45 min
Nelson → Kaiteriteri	1 hr
Nelson → St Arnaud / Nelson Lakes	1 hr 30
Nelson → Tākaka	1 hr 30
Nelson → Blenheim	1 hr 45
Nelson → Picton	2 hr
Nelson → Christchurch	5–6 hr, or 1 hr flying

Times on a good run. Check the Tākaka Hill and the Rai Valley road in bad weather.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).

Food, craft & the everyday

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Nelson has two things a city of this size has no right to: a serious craft-beer culture and a genuine community of working artists. Both come from the same place — decades of people choosing to live here and then having to make something.

Hops, beer and wine

Almost all of New Zealand's hops are grown on the Waimea plain, and that is not an incidental fact — it is why Nelson became the centre of the country's craft-brewing industry. There are more breweries per head here than anywhere else in New Zealand, and a genuine local culture around them rather than a tourist one.

The region also grows excellent aromatic wine — sauvignon blanc, chardonnay, pinot noir and particularly good rieslings and pinot gris — with cellar doors through the Moutere hills and out towards Māpua. Marlborough is next door if you want more.

What grows here

Apples and pears from the Motueka and Moutere districts, berries, kiwifruit, hops, and olives. Roadside stalls and orchard gates through the season, sold cheaply because there is so much of it.

The **Nelson Market** on Saturday morning is the region's fixture and unusual in the country for being as strong on craft as on produce — pottery, jewellery, glass, wood and textiles alongside the vegetables. The Motueka and Māpua markets are smaller and worth the trip.

And the sea: Tasman Bay is a working fishery, with scallops, mussels, snapper and blue cod. Golden Bay is known for its shellfish. Rules on gathering are real and enforced.

The arts community

This is a real thing rather than a brochure line. Nelson has been a centre for potters, glass artists, jewellers, painters and weavers since the 1960s, drawn by cheap land and good light, and the community has compounded ever since. There are working studios throughout the region, a strong gallery scene, the Suter art gallery in the city, and the World of WearableArt originated here.

Practically, for a clinician: it means a small city with a genuine cultural life, evening classes and studios you can actually join, and a social world that is not only sport. That is rarer in New Zealand's small cities than you might expect.

Eating out and the everyday

Central Nelson

A good, compact scene — Hardy and Trafalgar Streets for restaurants, wine bars and cafés, plus the breweries. Better than the city's size suggests.

Māpua & Motueka

The wharf at Māpua for a long lunch, Motueka for good cafés and a genuine alternative streak. Both worth the drive.

Groceries

All the main chains across Nelson and Richmond. Prices around the national average, with local produce noticeably cheaper.

Specialist ingredients

The honest weak point. Some Asian and Indian grocers, but the range is narrow compared with a main centre. Check before you commit if a particular cuisine matters — see [Finding your feet & your people](#).

The rhythm of the year

Summer is busy

Abel Tasman, Kaiteriteri and the campgrounds fill from Boxing Day to late January. Locals use the quieter beaches and enjoy February onwards.

Harvest runs autumn

Apples, hops and grapes, and a seasonal workforce arriving with them. The region smells of fruit.

Winter is mild and quiet

The coast rarely does anything harsh, the parks empty out, and the region belongs to residents again.

Joining in is easy

Tramping and cycling clubs, sailing, sport, studios and classes. A small city where turning up is genuinely enough.

Honest limitations

Retail is limited. Serious shopping means Christchurch, Wellington or online.

Big touring acts and major exhibitions mean a flight. The region's own festivals fill part of the gap.

Specialist imported groceries are genuinely hard to find. Most people build up an order a few times a year.

Three national parks

Nelson Tasman Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

No other city in New Zealand has three national parks within reach. Golden beaches an hour north, alpine lakes ninety minutes south, and one of the great wilderness tracks starting over the hill. This is the chapter that needs no argument.

THE CLAIM NO OTHER CITY CAN MAKE

3

NATIONAL PARKS WITHIN REACH OF THE CITY

Abel Tasman's golden coast lies an hour north, Nelson Lakes' alpine water ninety-odd minutes south, and Kahurangi's huge back country waits over the hill. No other New Zealand city can say it – bucket-list coastline here is an ordinary Sunday.

Each park gets its own section below, with the local tricks – the water taxi, the winter Heaphy ride, autumn over summer.

Abel Tasman

The country's smallest national park and possibly its most loved: granite headlands, golden sand, clear water and a coast track running the length of it. The southern gateway at **Kaiteriteri** is about an hour from Nelson, which means a beach that people fly across the world for is your ordinary Sunday.

The **Coast Track** is a three-to-five day Great Walk, but the clever local move is the water taxi – boat out, walk a section, boat back. Kayaking here is exceptional, and the seals and birdlife are close. Book ahead in summer; go in autumn if you can.

Kahurangi and Golden Bay

Kahurangi National Park

Vast, wild and far less visited – beech forest, marble karst, alpine tops and the second-largest park in the country.

The Heaphy Track

A Great Walk from Golden Bay through to the West Coast. Four to six days, and mountain-bikeable in winter.

Wharariki Beach

At the very top of the South Island past Tākaka – wind-carved arches, dunes and seal pups. Spectacular.

Te Waikoropupū Springs

Some of the clearest freshwater ever measured. A wāhi tapu, viewed from boardwalks, and quietly extraordinary.

Farewell Spit

A twenty-six kilometre sandspit and internationally important bird habitat at the top of the island.

Golden Bay itself

Tākaka, Pōhara and Collingwood – famously independent, artistic and close-knit. An hour and a half over the hill, and worth every corner.

Nelson Lakes and inland

Nelson Lakes National Park

Ninety minutes south to St Arnaud – Rotoiti and Rotoroa, beech forest to the water's edge, and alpine tops above. Cold, clear and beautiful.

The Angelus Hut circuit

One of the best two-day tramps in the country, on a ridgeline above the lakes.

Mount Richmond Forest Park

Between Nelson and Marlborough, with the Pelorus and Rai rivers and their swimming holes.

The Dun Mountain Trail

Mountain biking straight out of the city, on New Zealand's first railway line.

The Great Taste Trail

Flat, sealed, and linking cellar doors, orchards, estuary and coast. Family-friendly and useful.

In the city

The Māitai swimming holes, the Centre of New Zealand walk, the Grampians, Tahunanui beach and Queen's Gardens.

Further afield

Marlborough – 1 hr 45

The Sounds, the wineries, and the Queen Charlotte Track.

The West Coast — 3 hr

Down the Buller Gorge to Westport, the Paparoa Track and Punakaiki.

Kaikōura — 4 hr

Whales, dolphins and crayfish on the way to Christchurch.

Wellington — ferry from Picton

The capital for a weekend, with one of the world's most scenic ferry crossings on the way.

Useful links

[Tourism](#)

[Nelson Tasman NZ](#)



The region's official visitor site: the parks, the trails, the makers and what's on.

(<https://www.nelsontasman.nz/>)

Outdoors

Department of Conservation



Great Walks, huts, bookings and alerts for all three national parks.

(<https://www.doc.govt.nz/>)

Council



Local services, libraries, pools, parks and community programmes.

(<https://www.nelson.govt.nz/>)

Council



Richmond, Motueka, Golden Bay and the rural districts.

(<https://www.tasman.govt.nz/>)

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Nelson Tasman. Everything national – visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori – lives in **Moving to New Zealand**. When you'd like to talk it through, **we're here**, with no pressure and no pipeline.